

Carpathian OER Commons — Foundations

Background, Philosophy, and Concept of the Commons

Michel Garand | 2026-09-27 | Version v0.2 | CC BY-SA 4.0

Foundations paper under Section 11 of the pathway paper. No child appears in any form; the programme is described in standing format only. The site is not named, and nothing here places it. Every idea taken from elsewhere is named with its source and with what we change. Every point of Hutsul practice is marked [for the elders]: none of it is ours to state until they have confirmed, corrected, or withheld it.

Read this first. It says why the commons exists, what it stands on, and what it will not do. The modules say how the place is built; the pathway paper says how the guide is written and how it travels; the open hamlet paper says how the settlement grows and governs itself. This paper sits in front of all three and replaces none of them. It is published as a working draft, so that it can be changed in the open by the people it describes and the people who use it; nothing in it is carved in stone.

Two kinds of sentence run through it and are kept apart. Some state a conviction — the ground the work stands on. Others state what has been built, measured, or checked. A conviction is never offered here as a result. Section 3 says where the line runs; Section 8 says where each conviction stands against the evidence today. v0.2, 2026-09-27: the grounding documents are published beside this paper, in grounding/; Sections 3 and 6 say so.

1. What the commons is

The Carpathian OER Commons is an open guide to how one place in the Hutsul highlands of the Ukrainian Carpathians is built and run: a residential forest school for children and youth, a place of retreat and continuing education for adults, and a small settlement growing around them — a hamlet, *присілок*, the working term until the elders give theirs [for the elders].

The guide is written as modules, forty of them, each with the same shape and each carrying a maturity level that states what may be claimed from it. Beside the modules it carries the place's own pattern language, discovered and not imposed. Today two modules stand at a level the site's own experience backs, sixteen are at design stage, and twenty-two are empty rows, left visibly empty.

Open educational resources. Documents are released under CC BY-SA 4.0, drawings under a hardware licence still to be chosen, and measurement data openly, with attribution only. That places the guide inside the definition UNESCO adopted in 2019: "learning, teaching and research materials in any format and medium that reside in the public domain or are under copyright that have been released under an open license, that permit no-cost access, re-use, re-purpose, adaptation and redistribution by others." The licence makes the guide open. It does not by itself make it a commons.

Why a commons. In Elinor Ostrom's work a commons is a shared resource held by the people who depend on it, under rules they make and can change (Governing the Commons, 1990). The resources she studied — pastures, fisheries, irrigation — are used up by use: what one takes, another cannot. A guide is not; reading it takes nothing from it. What can be used up here is different: the trust of the household the

guide describes, the consent of the elders whose knowledge it draws on, the safety of a place in a country at war, and the honesty of the record. Those are what this commons has to govern. Knowledge treated as a commons is the subject of later work by Charlotte Hess and Elinor Ostrom (Understanding Knowledge as a Commons, 2007), and that is the reference when governance is built — in Phase 5 of the pathway, and not before. A commons with one member needs no constitution.

The measure. The guide is complete when another site has built from it, in another valley, and their figures sit in it beside ours. Not when every module is written, not when it is translated, not when it is published. The measure is taken from Open Source Ecology and narrowed (Section 5.1). It is the only measure this paper uses for the commons.

What changes in the people who take part is not measured by the guide and is not published. The programme's qualified staff hold that, inside the programme. The commons is measured by whether what it describes can be built again elsewhere.

2. Background

The initiative. The commons grows out of Soil and Peace, a community regeneration practice founded by Michel Garand, who writes the guide. Its conviction is that the hand that tends soil and the hand that tends what lies between people are the same hand. The place the guide describes is where that conviction is being worked out, on the ground, with a household and its neighbours. The project uses, and helps to develop, the framework of the Ubuntu Bioregional Economic Commons (UBEC) DAO, and draws on the Erdpuls open educational resources as worked examples.

Peace as infrastructure. Soil and Peace takes the phrase from peacebuilding, where an infrastructure for peace means the relationships and structures that carry a peace beyond its agreements, and reads it at the scale of a household and its ground. John Paul Lederach proposed the idea in Building Peace (1997), out of mediation work in Nicaragua. In his words, "we are not merely interested in 'ending' something that is not desired. We are oriented toward the building of relationships that in their totality form new patterns, processes, and structures." Our reading changes the scale and the material — a spring, a forest, a record, a working relationship between neighbours — and keeps his point: the aim is not only to end what is unwanted but to build what holds.

The guide is the checkable case. That peace grows from tended ground is a conviction, and this paper does not claim it as a finding. One part of it can be checked. Documentation that others build from, and that outlasts the people who wrote it, is infrastructure in the plainest sense. If a second site builds from the guide and its figures come back into it, that much will have been shown — for the guide, not for peace.

Why a guide. The place is being built in wartime, in mountains that run through seven states: Ukraine, Romania, Poland, Slovakia, Hungary, Serbia, and Czechia. Other initiatives in the range face the same questions — water, power, sanitation, winter, safeguarding, how to hold land — with the same scarcity of money and time. Many published projects describe what worked and leave out what failed and what it cost. The guide exists so that the next site does not repeat the expensive mistakes, and so that what was found here is offered as method, never as a template.

What the war changes. The war is the ground the work stands on, not its subject. It sets hard limits on what can be published: no child in any form, no site named while the decision on naming it is open, no plan that places a valley, no data finer than valley resolution, and a wartime review before every release. Those limits are not an inconvenience to be engineered around. They are part of the method, and a site in peacetime may keep them for its own reasons.

3. What the commons stands on

Every idea in this paper grew somewhere else first. What we stand on was laid down by others, the way soil is — in layers, from what lived before: a practice of tending ground, a way of documenting that others can build from, a way of looking that lets a place speak first, words lent by peoples who were here long before this work. We receive them as the ground receives what falls on it — slowly, changed by what they meet, until they feed something that was not there before. We take nothing whole. We take as a root takes: only what it can turn into its own growth, and only where it stands. What is ours is not the ideas but the ground they have fallen on — and the honesty to name where each one grew.

The documents this paper draws on speak in two registers. The grounding documents — a philosophy of the living forest, written by Michel Garand with the host household; a comparative survey of spiritual traditions; the programme proposal — speak from conviction. They are published beside this paper, in grounding/, as working drafts open to co-creation. The guide speaks from measurement. The commons needs both, and neither may borrow the other's authority.

Held as ground. Four convictions, stated as convictions:

- **Care circulates.** We hold that where work is done together, care runs in every direction until no one is only a giver or only a receiver. The guide's forms of it are concrete: joint attribution, the household's time counted as contribution, cultural work to be funded by gift. The guide does not say that care is the only currency. Every module carries a cost line in hryvnia, and it would be untrue.
- **Land and people are regenerated together.** The work on the ground and the work between people are one work, seen from two sides. The guide measures the ground side — a spring's yield, seedling survival, returning species — and says nothing about the other.
- **Peace is grown as infrastructure.** Section 2.

- **A place teaches, when it is attended to.** Every place has its own pattern language; the task is to notice it, not to invent it (Section 5.2).

Not claimed. The guide does not claim that the forest heals, that the method changes the people who take part, or that the place has become what it hopes to be. Those are the reasons the work is done. They are not results the work has shown, and no module is written as if they were.

The bridge. One practice already carries both registers at once: the dialogue between the body and the instrument. A hand in the soil says sheltered here, exposed there; a thermometer gives a number; neither replaces the other, and the gap between them is where the learning is. The commons takes that as its discipline for everything it writes: a conviction may say what to look at; only a measurement may say what was found.

4. Principles

4.1 Not one to one

No language, method, or tradition is taken over whole — not Alexander's, not Steiner's, not the Erdpuls method's, not any people's. And none is offered whole: a site that builds from the guide takes modules, not the model, and grows its own form from its own ground. The rule runs both ways, and that is its point.

Its source is Alexander's caveat on his own book: "each pattern may be looked upon as a hypothesis, like one of the hypotheses of science" (A Pattern Language, 1977, p. xv). What we change is its direction. He applied it to what he offered; we apply it also to what we take.

4.2 With, not for

MIT, nicht FÜR — the ethical spine of Soil and Peace, kept in its German: building with a place and its people rather than for them. In the guide it governs three relations. Between the author and the place: the guide describes our own work, never a place's life on its behalf. Between the guide and its readers: replication is an invitation, never an export. Between the work and those who take part: everyone is a co-creator (Section 4.4). Work that begins as done with people and lasts long enough becomes work they lead; that is what "with" means over time, not a third term.

4.3 Honest before useful

A module that says "we have not tested this" is worth more than one that reads well. Every module states its level at the top, from L0, an idea, to L5, improved by others and merged back, and readers act on the level, not on the prose. Every figure is measured, quoted, or marked [set] or [assumed]; a cost without a date is a rumour. The failure of open documentation is work at one level published in the language of a higher one. This paper is held to the same rule, and Section 8 applies it to its own convictions.

4.4 Co-creators

Everyone who takes part — the household, the trades, the elders, guests, residents, the people of other sites — is a co-creator. The living-lab literature says users. The Erdpuls method does not, and the commons follows it, because a pattern language that people have not discovered and named themselves is someone else's, imposed. Attribution follows the work: where it was joint, the credit is joint. An open licence that quietly credits shared work to one author is, in the pathway paper's words, a theft dressed as generosity.

4.5 Not ours to give

Knowledge that belongs to a people or to particular persons is not open because someone wrote it down. Hutsul practice — forms, songs, craft, the knowledge of a valley — enters the guide only with the consent of those whose knowledge it is, on terms they set, and some of it will not enter at all [for the elders]. The default is to describe our own use of a practice and point to its holders. Sacred sites, holy ground, and graves are recorded nowhere, in the workshop or in publication, unless the elders ask. The same holds for every tradition named in Section 6: we say whose it is and how we use it, and we do not speak for it.

4.6 Across the borders

The commons is named for the range, not for a country. The frame is bioregional. Peter Berg and Raymond Dasmann introduced the bioregion and reinhabitation as paired terms in "Reinhabiting California" (The Ecologist, 1977), and wrote, in the essay as reprinted the following year, that "the final boundaries of a bioregion are best described by the people who have lived within it, through human recognition of the realities of living-in-place." Here that sentence is a rule: the boundaries of the place, like its names, are for the people who live in it and for the elders to draw [for the elders].

What travels across the borders: sizing methods, the order of decisions, the record of what failed, the maturity discipline, the safeguarding architecture. What does not: regulation, prices, trades, species, planting calendars, language. Each module carries one regulatory row per country, dated and signed by whoever checked it. An empty row stays visibly empty, so that a reader in Romania can see at a glance that nobody has checked Romania.

5. Where the method comes from

5.1 Documentation as the deliverable

Open Source Ecology, founded by Marcin Jakubowski in 2003, sets out to publish open designs for the fifty industrial machines it counts as needed for a small civilisation with modern comforts, the Global Village Construction Set. Four of its habits are taken. Documentation is the deliverable: a thing built and

not documented is not finished. Modularity: independent parts, so that a reader takes the two they need. Lifetime design and serviceability: built to be repaired by those who use it. Replication as the measure of success.

Four are not taken. The machines: the technologies here are a cistern, a reed bed, a wood stove, a nursery, mostly older than industry and built by local trades. The completeness claim: the guide covers what this place does and says where it stops. The rhetoric of post-scarcity and civilisation-building: the register here is a household in a war, saying what it built and what it cost. Open by default, everywhere: children, a wartime location, and knowledge that is not ours to license set limits that a hardware project does not meet.

5.2 Discovery, not imposition

Christopher Alexander and his colleagues set out 253 patterns in *A Pattern Language* (1977), from the region to the construction detail. In their definition, a pattern "describes a problem which occurs over and over again in our environment, and then describes the core of the solution to that problem."

The Erdpuls method departs from him once: it arrives with a way of discovering a place's own pattern language, not with a language to impose. The commons departs a second time, as the open hamlet paper sets out. Alexander's patterns are prompts for looking, never a specification. A pattern of his that the place does not carry is a question — what answers that tension here — not a gap to fill. And the place may hold forms that are not patterns in his sense at all: a rhythm, a movement, a relation held in custom rather than in building.

Three kinds of pattern are kept apart: the place's, named by the household, the co-creators, and the elders; Alexander's, cited by number and name as prompts; and a module's own design rules, which stay inside the module and are tested by its maturity level.

5.3 Delicate empiricism

"Es gibt eine zarte Empirie, die sich mit dem Gegenstand innigst identisch macht und dadurch zur eigentlichen Theorie wird" — there is a delicate empiricism that makes itself wholly one with its object, and so becomes theory in the true sense (Goethe, *Maximen und Reflexionen*; the translation is ours). A second maxim gives the order of work: no phenomenon explains itself; only many, surveyed together and methodically ordered, give something that may count as theory.

The Erdpuls method takes from Goethe the order of knowing: observation before explanation, the body as the first instrument, simple measurement as the second. Later writers, Henri Bortoft among them, have set Goethe's way of seeing out in stages; those stages are theirs, not Goethe's, and are cited as such where they are used.

5.4 Growing like a plant

Goethe's *Metamorphosis of Plants* (1790) — one form, expressed differently wherever it grows — gives the settlement its way of growing. Roots before shoots: the place is walked and measured before anything is built. Grow from where it stands: from the existing buildings, the water, the slope; build on the poorer ground and keep the best. Many small parts, no single centre, so that the loss of one does not end the whole. Grow in season. Shed and compost what fails: a failed design is recorded, taken down, and returned to the record as what we got wrong. Seed, not copy: another site takes the method and grows its own form, which is what L4 means. Alexander asked the same of a community in *The Oregon Experiment* (1975): piecemeal growth rather than a plan built at once.

This is a metaphor for method, not a claim about plants. The phrase echoes Aldo Leopold's "thinking like a mountain" (*A Sand County Almanac*, 1949). The picture of a living body with no single centre, sensing everywhere, is close to Stefano Mancuso's argument about plant intelligence, which other biologists dispute. Neither is used as evidence.

5.5 Citizen science and the living lab

The term citizen science has two origins, reached independently. Alan Irwin (*Citizen Science*, 1995) meant a science answerable to citizens' concerns and knowledge that citizens produce themselves; Rick Bonney (1996) meant members of the public contributing data to a research project. Here, observation and measurement are done by the people who live, work, and learn at the place, with the body first and simple instruments second, and the practice stands nearer Irwin's sense.

It departs from the openness the other sense assumes, and from the Erdpuls method, whose documents provide for contributing freely to open platforms. Data leaves the site only at valley resolution: no coordinates, no dates tied to a session, no account belonging to or naming a child. Any contribution to a public platform is made by an adult, with the location obscured, after the wartime review. The departure is deliberate, and a replicating site can weigh its two reasons for itself: a country at war, and children who cannot consent to being placed.

Living lab is used as a descriptive frame, with no connection claimed to any outside network or certification body. It means five things together: work in a real setting; co-creation; many parties at the table — household, trades, elders, guests, other sites; many methods; and a cycle of trying, measuring, and revising. The maturity levels are that cycle made explicit.

5.6 Head, heart, and hand

Learning with head, heart, and hand is Johann Heinrich Pestalozzi's (1746–1827). Rudolf Steiner's thinking, feeling, and willing is a later parallel; the Erdpuls method draws on it as a developmental psychology, not as a worldview, and the commons needs only Pestalozzi's form.

The four stages the Erdpuls method uses — Awareness, Acknowledgment, Attitude, Action — are its own. The method is designed and documented in the Erdpuls OER collection, in the Pattern Discovery Toolkit, EN v1.3, and the Pattern Language Assembly Guide, EN v1.2. It is claimed here as designed and documented, and no more.

6. Borrowed words

Each word below belongs to someone. This section says whose, and how the commons holds it.

Toloka. Neighbours doing together a piece of work none could do alone, repaid with a feast. The practice is not only Carpathian: its names run from talka in Latvian and Lithuanian and talgud in Estonian to tloka in Polish, kalaka in Hungarian, and toloka in Ukrainian. Shared work has also been turned into owed work: Lithuanian estate regulations of 1557 already list talka among the duties peasants owed the estate. One study of the Hutsul region records toloka also as family pasture held across generations — family land, not common land. Which sense this valley uses is for the elders [for the elders]. The guide uses the word for shared work freely given, and never as a name for unpaid labour an economy depends on.

Ubuntu. The Nguni proverb umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu, in Xhosa and Zulu: a person is a person through other persons. "I am, because we are; and since we are, therefore I am" is John Mbiti's rendering (African Religions and Philosophy, 1969), not the proverb's translation. The idea is contested within African philosophy; Mbiti, among others, warns against reading it as a claim that Africans are naturally harmony-seeking. The framework this commons works within, UBEC, the Ubuntu Bioregional Economic Commons DAO, carries the word in its name. We describe our use of it — that personhood here is read as reaching into the land a community belongs to — and say that this extension is ours, not the proverb's. We do not speak for it.

Social threefolding. Rudolf Steiner proposed it in memoranda of 1917 and campaigned for it in 1919: freedom in cultural life, equality in the life of rights, fraternity in economic life. The hamlet's adults use it as a lens — three questions put to a decision: whose freedom is this; what holds for everyone alike; what need, met by which association. It is held as method, not worldview; never taught to children; asked of no family. It is contested, and so is its author: the 1917 memoranda cast Western democracy as Anglo-American domination of central Europe. Communities partly organised on these lines have also shown where it breaks. Camphill co-workers lived for decades unpaid and housed as families until, from 2014 at one of them, that model met charity governance and employment rules. No economy here is designed to rest on unpaid residents without a footing in Ukrainian labour law. Safeguarding sits in the sphere of rights, beyond the reach of the other two.

Forest school. The name belongs to an existing movement: settings that emerged in Denmark in the 1950s, reached the United Kingdom through Bridgwater College in 1993, and have had a professional body there, the Forest School Association, since 2012. The commons uses the words descriptively. It claims no affiliation and no accreditation.

Hutsul. The people and the highland whose practice this place stands inside. Nothing Hutsul in the commons is ours: the form of settlement, the enclosed homestead (ґражда) and the outlying group of homesteads (кyт), the polonyna and its season, the local sense of toloka, songs, dances, and the customs of mourning are for the elders to confirm, correct, or withhold [for the elders]. Where the grounding documents draw on them, those passages are marked for the elders and wait on their word; nothing in them is stated as confirmed until the elders have spoken.

The world's traditions. The comparative survey behind the philosophy names traditions from the Baltic to Aotearoa as kin to the practice here. The commons names a tradition by its people, never practises it as its own, and never uses it as evidence. That a shape recurs across many traditions says something about people. It does not show that a method works.

7. What the commons will not do

- Place a child in any form: no name, face, detail, date, or count. The programme is described in standing format only.
 - Name the site, or publish anything that places it — a plan with distances or terrain, a photograph with a face, signage, or a ridgeline, data finer than valley resolution — until the decision on naming the site is taken.
 - Claim above its level, or print a figure that is not measured, quoted, or marked.
 - Publish what the elders have not consented to, or anything of a resident household's life without that household's own Gate 1.
 - Teach a doctrine. The convictions are lived in the open, where a family can see them before choosing; none is taught as truth, and no family's faith is asked to move.
 - Speak for a people or a tradition (Sections 4.5 and 6).
 - Sell. No module is held back to create demand for help. Help beyond the guide is a separate arrangement and does not close the guide.
 - Launch. No network, no campaign, no movement. One other site first.
 - Build an economy on unpaid residents, or on work that is owed rather than given.
 - Carry application or funder material. Anything naming an entity goes to funders, not to the repository.
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8. Where the convictions stand against the evidence

- **The method travels.** Tested when a site in another valley builds from the modules and returns its figures, which is L4. Today: no such site.
- **The guide stands without its writers.** Tested when a site builds from it with no help from the people who wrote it. Today: untested.
- **Land regenerates with the work.** The nursery and planting modules would measure seedling survival and returning ground flora across seasons. Today: the nursery module designed at L1, planting at L0, no season measured.
- **A place teaches, when it is attended to.** Tested when pattern cards are confirmed by independent observers across groups and seasons. Today: the settlement walk not yet made, the pattern record not yet begun.
- **Care circulates.** The guide measures nothing that would test it and claims nothing from it.
- **Peace grows from tended ground.** Nor this. The guide is one piece of infrastructure the conviction would predict; if it is replicated, that shows the guide works, not that peace grew.

The commons stands on convictions it cannot prove, and on a method it has designed and documented but not yet seen travel. Every module says the same of itself, at its own level.

9. Who reads this first

- **The household reads it first.** The paper describes the place the household lives in and the practice it shares. It passes the household's Gate 1 before anyone else reads it.
- **It is written for a replicating site.** Sections 4, 5, and 7 are what travels. A site that reads them and takes two modules has used the commons as intended.
- **A reviewer or a funder** reads Sections 1, 3, and 8: what is claimed, and what is not.
- **The elders** are not sent a document. What this paper marks for them is taken to them in conversation, and their answers change the text.

It is both a standalone paper and the preface to the guide. It is written and checked in the workshop now; once released, it is the page every module's Provenance section points to.

Open decisions it touches, carried from the project prompt and decided elsewhere: whether the guide names the site, and when; how the elders' material is handled; who the co-authors are, module by module; how much of the programme, and of the adult strand, is published; legal form and ownership before anyone lives on the site.

10. Release record

This paper is released with the guide, from foundations/, as a working draft, with the grounding documents beside it in grounding/. It is changed as the work goes on, in the open, and each new version is released the same way, with both lines below dated again.

- **Gate 1:** 2026-09-27, the household, recorded by Michel Garand — for publication online as a working draft, open to co-creation and to change; v0.2 with the grounding documents published beside it.
 - **Wartime review:** 2026-09-27, Michel Garand — the paper names Michel Garand, Soil and Peace, UBEC, and Erdpuls, and no place; accepted.
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11. Sources

Searched 2026-09-27; to be re-checked before any release.

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- This project: the project prompt, v0.2; the pathway paper, EN v0.4; the open hamlet paper, EN v0.1.

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